

Hackles Teacher Academy • Module 1: Why This Matters

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

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FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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About 60 minutes (Quick Start: about 10). No tech background needed.

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FIELD NOTE	No. 1
At a glance. Meet the real risks kids face online, learn which numbers to trust (and which to check), and see why a calm, skills-first approach beats scary warnings. Three short activities and a self-check. Quick Start learners: read "The short version" and the four Calm Facts, then jump to Module 2.	

Learning objectives

BY THE END OF this module you will be able to:

1. Name the main online risks children face, in plain and calm language.
2. Explain what current evidence says about how common some risks are, and flag which statistics need to be verified before you repeat them to a parent, a principal or a class.
3. Say why scare messages and one-off assemblies tend not to work. Say what works better.
4. Explain "Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell." in your own words.
5. Describe your role: recognition and response, not investigation or tech support.

Welcome: the plumber and the lifeguard

A PLUMBER DOESN'T NEED to understand every pipe to teach what to do when water comes through the ceiling: where the shutoff valve is, who to call, and don't panic. A lifeguard doesn't teach swimming by describing drowning. She teaches strokes, practices rescues, and keeps the rules short. Kids who learn to swim get safer, while kids who are only told "the water is dangerous" get nervous, or tune you out, or both.

Your job is closer to both of those than to engineering. You help children **know where the shutoff valve is** (tell a trusted adult), **practice the strokes** (pause, check, say no, block, report) and **stay calm**. This module is about the water, meaning what kids actually run into, and most of it is more ordinary than you fear.

The short version

- Most children use technology safely most of the time. We are building skills, not fear.
- The risks are real, and a few are serious. Knowing the main kinds helps you recognize them.
- Shame is the biggest obstacle to children getting help. Your reaction to a small "oops" teaches them whether it is safe to tell you about a big one.
- What works: practice, repetition, calm, and a clear "tell a trusted adult" message. What does not: one-off scary assemblies and "don't ever share personal information" lectures.

Part 1: The risks, in plain language

HERE ARE THE SEVEN risk families the Hackles kit teaches about. For each: what it is, what it looks like to a child, and the kind of hackles it should raise. You do not need to memorize details. You need to recognize the shape.

1. SCAMS AND TRICKS

What it is. A message, pop-up, comment or "friend" promises something (game money, a prize) or threatens something (your account will be deleted) to get a password, code, money or click.

What kids see. "Free Robux! Click here." A friend's account asking for a gift card. A pop-up saying a virus was found.

Hackles trigger. Urgency, secrecy, too good to be true, a request for a password, code or payment.

2. TAKEN-OVER ACCOUNTS

What it is. Someone gets into a child's game, email or social account (through a fake login page, a password reused from a leaked site, or a code handed over) and uses it to scam friends, buy things or post.

What kids see. "I can't log in." "Someone is messaging my friends from my account."

Hackles trigger. Anyone asking for a login code. A link that asks you to log in "to verify."

3. UNKIND BEHAVIOR ONLINE

What it is. Mean group chats, leaving someone out, embarrassing pictures, passed-around screenshots, rumors. It follows kids home because their phone does.

What kids see. A private message screenshotted and shared. A chat that goes silent when one kid posts. A "joke" video of a classmate.

Hackles trigger. Feeling targeted, laughed at, or pressured to join in.

4. PRESSURE FROM SOMEONE MET ONLINE

What it is. A friendly player or follower becomes increasingly flattering, gift-giving and secretive, and asks to move to a private app, keep secrets or send pictures. It may be an adult pretending to be a child, an older teen, or someone a child half-knows. This is often called grooming; the pattern matters more than the label.

What kids see. A "friend" who always has time and says "don't tell your parents, they would not understand."

Hackles trigger. Secrecy, "let's talk somewhere else," gifts, special treatment, boundary tests.

5. SEXTORTION (THREATS AFTER A PICTURE IS SHARED)

What it is. Someone threatens to share a private picture (real or fake) unless the child pays or sends more. Most cases are financially motivated: offenders, often organized and using fake accounts, demand money, gift cards or payment apps. Every part of it is the fault of the person making the threat, never the child.

What kids see. A friendly account, a fast move to private chat, a picture exchange, then "pay or I send this to your friends."

Hackles trigger. Very fast escalation, a request to change platforms, a threat. The response: stop, save the text evidence, tell a trusted adult, report. Never pay.

6. FAKE PICTURES, VIDEOS AND VOICES (DEEPPAKES)

What it is. AI tools can make a picture, video or voice that looks real. Some are used to embarrass or threaten classmates ("nudify" apps). Some copy a family member's voice in a scam call.

What kids see. A fake picture of a classmate in a group chat. A call that sounds like Grandma asking for money.

Hackles trigger. Anything "shocking" that arrives with pressure to share it. Urgent calls demanding money.

7. CHATBOTS THAT ACT LIKE FRIENDS (AI COMPANIONS)

What it is. Chatbots that talk in a warm, personal way. They can feel caring, but they are not people, can be wrong, may agree with whatever a child says, and are no substitute for a trusted adult.

What kids see. A chatbot "friend" that remembers their day, flatters them and is always available.

Hackles trigger. Using a chatbot for serious worries instead of a person. Sharing personal details.

THE THREAD THAT CONNECTS THEM

Notice how often the same few features appear: **pressure, secrecy, a request, and a move to somewhere more private.** The kit teaches children to notice those features, whatever the app is. This is why Hackles teaches behaviors, not apps. By the time you finish training, the apps will have changed. The pattern will not have.

MAKE IT STICK

Try This Now (3 minutes). Pick one of the seven risks. In 30 seconds, tell a partner (or say aloud to the room) which of the four features it contains: pressure, secrecy, a request, a move somewhere more private. Swap and do a second risk. Notice how often the same features come back. That is why we teach patterns, not apps.

Part 2: What the evidence says (and how to hold numbers lightly)

ONLINE SAFETY IS A field where statistics are everywhere, many of them inflated, and many from companies selling something. A good teacher can be calm and credible by doing two things: **quote from primary sources**, and **mark uncertainty**. Throughout this Academy, [VERIFY] means "check the source before you repeat or print this."

CALM FACT 1: MOST KIDS ARE NOT IN TROUBLE

Surveys consistently show most young people use technology without serious harm. The point of teaching is to give every child skills for the minority of moments that go wrong. (Evidence for the general claim: multiple national surveys by Pew Research Center and Common Sense Media; check their latest reports. [VERIFY])

CALM FACT 2: THE SERIOUS HARMS ARE REAL, AND SOME ARE GROWING

- The National Center for Missing and Exploited Children (NCMEC) reported more than 50,000 reports of financially motivated sextortion in 2025, up from more than 36,000 the year before [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: ncmec.org/blog/2026/ncmec-releases-new-sextortion-data-2025].

- The FBI's 2025 Internet Crime Report (IC3) reported tens of thousands of sextortion submissions and noted victims at risk of self-harm. [VERIFY exact figures in the report]
- Thorn research (2025) found about 1 in 5 young people aged 13 to 20 reported a sextortion experience, and that 44 percent of sextortion victims said their images were recorded or screenshotted without consent [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: thorn.org, State of Sextortion in 2025].
- Thorn reported that about 1 in 17 teens say deepfake nudes have been created of them, and about 1 in 8 know someone who was targeted [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: thorn.org; "1 in 25" was wrong for Thorn: it is the UNICEF figure for some countries].
- Most victims in the reported data are boys aged 14 to 17, but any child can be targeted. [VERIFY]

How to use these: share the shape ("this is real and rising, and kids who tell early get more options") rather than a scary number. If a family asks, point to the organization's own page and say "here is the current figure."

CALM FACT 3: KIDS ARE USING AI AND SOCIAL TOOLS IN LARGE NUMBERS

- Pew Research Center reported in December 2025 that 64 percent of US teens say they use AI chatbots, including about 3 in 10 teens who use them daily [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: pewresearch.org, 9 Dec 2025].
- Common Sense Media (2025) reported that 72 percent of teens had used AI companions at least once, and that about one in three AI-companion users had chosen to discuss serious matters with an AI instead of a person [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: commonsensemedia.org press release, July 2025].
- CDC's Youth Risk Behavior Survey (2023) found that more than one in six high school students were bullied electronically in the previous year [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: cdc.gov/youth-violence/about/about-bullying.html]. Rates differ by group; check the YRBS data tables for exact figures before quoting them.

CALM FACT 4 (A DIFFERENT KIND OF FACT): MANY CHILDREN DO NOT TELL

The UNICEF Disrupting Harm project found, in its first 13 countries (Africa and Southeast Asia), that about one-third of children who experienced online sexual exploitation and abuse told no one, and only about 3 percent reported it to the police or a helpline [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: unicef.org/innocenti, Disrupting Harm]. The figures come from those countries, not the US. This is the most important number for teachers. It means the single most powerful thing we can teach is the following: **telling is safe, telling is never getting in trouble, and the people you tell will help.**

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS WORKS, AND WHAT DOES NOT

The most-cited review of youth internet safety education is by Finkelhor and colleagues (2021, in *Trauma, Violence, & Abuse*). Its key conclusions, summarized:

APPROACH	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SUGGESTS
Active, skill-based lessons (role-play, rehearsal, discussion)	Better supported by prevention science than lectures
Programs that are structured, repeated and well delivered	Better than one-off sessions
Targeting behaviors and relationships (not just apps)	Recommended, because platforms change quickly
One-off assemblies and single videos	Weak; unlikely to change behavior
Information-only lessons (for example, "don't share personal information")	Weak; many such lessons did not meet basic prevention-education standards
Fear appeals and stern warnings	Evidence is mixed, and they can backfire when there is no clear action to take. Direct evidence specific to online safety is thin. [VERIFY before claiming "proven to backfire"]

Two honest caveats: much of the best evidence comes from an adjacent field (school-based child sexual abuse prevention, where active skill practice improved knowledge, protective behaviors and disclosure), and there is no rigorous trial yet of a modern K-12 curriculum on sextortion or deepfakes. That is why Module 8 builds in simple evaluation.

A WORD ABOUT "STRANGER DANGER"

The old slogan told children to fear strangers. But much online harm starts with accounts that look like peers, or people a child has half-met in a game. The skill we teach is not "avoid strangers" but "notice pressure, secrecy and requests, whoever is asking, and tell."

Part 3: Why not just scare them?

WHEN SOMETHING IS FRIGHTENING, a stern warning feels responsible. Hackles does something different, for three reasons.

1. **Fear without a skill is just fear.** A child told "predators are out there" has nothing to do with that information. A child who has practiced "I'm going to tell my teacher about this" does.
2. **Fear makes telling harder.** Children say shame and fear of punishment are major reasons they stay silent. Warnings that imply "you would be foolish if this happened to you" make a later disclosure feel risky.

3. **Fear fades; practice sticks.** One assembly is forgotten by Friday. A skill rehearsed three times across a term tends to stay. (And kids know when an adult is exaggerating.)

So Hackles teaches the opposite of panic: **notice, pause, check, tell**. It treats false alarms as a success, repeats "it is never your fault," and tells children plainly that the adult world, including you, is on their side.

Part 4: The Hackles idea, in your own words

"Hackles" are what rise on the back of your neck when something feels off. The program teaches kids to notice that feeling and act on it:

1. **Hackles up?** Notice: something feels odd, too good, pushy, secret or scary.
2. **Pause.** Stop. Do nothing yet.
3. **Check.** Is it real? Who is it from? What do they want?
4. **Tell.** A trusted adult, every time, with no shame.

Two promises go with it: **a false alarm is fine and welcome**, and **it is never the child's fault**. If a child ignored their hackles or was tricked anyway, the response is help, not blame. "Trust your hackles" never means "you must always be right."

Part 5: Your role

YOU ARE NOT HERE to be the internet's police or a cybersecurity expert. Your role has five parts, each practiced in this Academy: **Recognize** (Modules 1, 3), **Teach** (4, 5), **Listen** (6), **Report and hand off** (6) and **Include and partner** (7).

Equally important, here is what is **not** your job: investigating who did it, confronting a suspect, viewing images, searching phones, counseling, or fixing every device. Not doing those things is not a failure. It is the correct response.

Do it yourself

ACTIVITY 1.1: THE THREE-MINUTE HONESTY MAP (5 MINUTES)

ON PAPER, DRAW THREE columns: **Cool with it, A bit nervous, Help!** Place each topic where it fits today: passwords, phishing, group chats, online games, AI chatbots, talking to a student about something serious, reporting a concern, talking to parents about online safety. Circle the two you most want to move left by the end of the Academy. Fold the paper and keep it for Module 8. It is private: nobody will ask to see it. Every teacher's map looks different, and many experts have a "Help!" column too.

ACTIVITY 1.2: NUMBER DETECTIVE (8 MINUTES)

1. Pick one number from Part 2 (for example, the NCMEC sextortion figure).
2. Using a school or home device, find the original source (the organization's own page, not a news story about it) and its exact wording.
3. Answer: Who published it? What year, and who was counted or surveyed? Does it match what this Academy said? Is it a count of reports or a share of a survey? (They mean different things.)
4. Write one calm sentence for a parent. Example: "National data show reports of this kind of threat have risen sharply, which is why we teach children that telling a trusted adult early is always the right move."

Specialist Challenge: Compare how two news outlets summarize the same report. What changed between the original and the headline?

ACTIVITY 1.3: WARNING VS SKILL, THE REWRITE GAME (10 MINUTES)

Rewrite each fear-based message as a skill-based message. The first is done for you.

FEAR MESSAGE	SKILL MESSAGE
"Strangers online want to hurt you, so never talk to anyone."	"If someone online asks for secrets or pictures, or wants to move to a private chat, your hackles should go up. Pause, and tell a grown-up you trust."
"If you share your password, you will get hacked."	(your turn)
"Don't ever post anything, it will ruin your life."	(your turn)
"That chatbot is dangerous. Stay off it."	(your turn)

Check yourself: a good skill message names (1) a signal to notice, (2) one concrete action, and (3) a hopeful, shame-free tone.

Sample answers: "A password is like a toothbrush: yours alone. If someone asks for it, hackles up, pause, and check with a trusted adult." / "Before you post, ask: would I be okay if my whole school, and my grandmother, saw

this? If you are not sure, ask a trusted person." / "Chatbots can be helpful or fun, but they are not people and can be wrong. For anything serious or worrying, talk to a person you trust."

Scenario Studio

EACH SCENARIO BELOW IS a real-feeling classroom moment. Read it, think (or discuss with a colleague), then compare with the expert-response guidance. There is no single right answer. The guidance describes a strong approach.

SCENARIO 1.A: "MY PRINCIPAL WANTS AN ASSEMBLY"

Your principal says, "Let's get a speaker in to scare them straight about predators. One big assembly and we are done for the year." You are asked to organize it.

Discuss: What are the strengths and limits of an assembly? What could you propose that keeps what the principal wants (a visible, serious response) and adds what works, and how would you say it without sounding like you are rejecting the idea?

Expert-response guidance. Affirm the goal ("I love that we are taking this seriously"), then offer both/and: a short kickoff paired with ten short classroom lessons across the year, which is what the evidence favors (Finkelhor and colleagues, 2021: programs with active skill practice and repeated dosage fit better than one-off sessions). [VERIFY] Offer to pilot with one grade and report back. Invite the principal to a lesson rather than lecturing them.

SCENARIO 1.B: "IT'S JUST A GAME"

During a casual chat, a fourth grader says, "I play Blockville every night with a guy named Max. He's 14. He gave me free coins." Other students nod and say they have "friends" in the game too.

Discuss: Which of the seven risk families might be involved, and which might not? What is a calm, curious first response, what would you ask and avoid asking, and does this require reporting right now? What would change your answer?

Expert-response guidance. Stay calm and curious: "Tell me more about Blockville. What do you like about it?" Gifts, an older "friend" and nightly contact are the shape of a pattern worth watching, but one comment is not a disclosure of harm. Keep the child talking and feeling safe. Do not interrogate, and do not say "that is dangerous." You might say: "It is cool that you have game friends. If anyone asks for secrets, pictures or to move to a private app, your hackles should go up, and you tell a grown-up you trust, no matter what." Make a quiet note and let your counselor know, per your

school's process. If the child mentions secrecy, pictures, threats or being asked to move to a private app, treat it as a potential disclosure and use the First 10 Minutes (Module 6) and your reporting policy. [VERIFY your district policy]

Reflection prompts

WRITE A FEW SENTENCES for each. These are for you alone, and you may skip any prompt.

1. What comes to mind when you hear "online safety": a fear, a rule, a memory, a headline?
2. Which of the seven risk families do you know least about? What would help?
3. What would it mean for a child in your class to know "telling is always okay"?

Self-check (10 questions)

COVER THE ANSWER KEY, answer in your head or on paper, then check. A score of 8 or more earns a green light for Module 2.

1. Which description best matches the Hackles approach to risk?
 - a) Rely on filters to block everything.
 - b) Scare children enough that they avoid technology.
 - c) Teach children to notice a signal, pause, check, and tell a trusted adult.
 - d) Teach children never to talk to anyone online.
2. True or false: "Most children use technology safely most of the time" is a reason to skip online safety lessons.
3. A statistic comes from a news article. What is the best step before repeating it to parents?
 - a) Round it up so it has impact.
 - b) Ignore all statistics.
 - c) Share it only with students.
 - d) Find the original source and confirm the figure.
4. Which is a common pattern in grooming and sextortion?
 - a) A parent who sets screen limits.
 - b) An account that is friendly, moves quickly to private chat, and asks for secrecy.

c) A teacher who gives homework.

d) A stranger who looks scary.

5. The research suggests which kind of lesson is better supported?

a) Repeated, skill-based lessons with role-play.

b) A scary video.

c) A handout of rules.

d) A single 45-minute assembly.

6. True or false: Trust your hackles means a child must always be right when they feel something is off.

7. A child says someone in a game gave them free coins and asked them to move to a private chat. What is the best first response?

a) Ignore it.

b) Stay calm, thank them, and ask a curious open question.

c) Ask the child to show you the whole chat history on their device.

d) "That is dangerous! Never talk to them again!"

8. Which is NOT part of a teacher's role in Hackles?

a) Report as required.

b) Notice and listen.

c) Hand off to trained people.

d) Investigate and confront the suspect.

9. What is the main reason many children do not tell an adult when something goes wrong?

a) They do not know how to use a phone.

b) They are not interested.

c) Shame and fear of being blamed or punished.

d) They think adults are too busy at night.

10. Which is a well-formed skill message?

a) "If an account asks for your password or code, hackles up: pause and check with a trusted adult."

b) "Hackers are everywhere."

c) "Everyone online is lying."

d) "Never share anything online."

ANSWER KEY

Q	ANSWER	WHY
1	c	Hackles teaches skills and a clear action, not fear or avoidance.
2	False	Most kids are fine, which is why we build skills calmly. The minority of serious cases is why we teach at all.
3	d	Primary sources, and check the wording (reports versus surveys).
4	b	Pressure, secrecy and a move to a private channel are the pattern.
5	a	Active, repeated skill practice is better supported than one-offs.
6	False	False alarms are welcome, and children who were tricked are never at fault.
7	b	Calm and curious keeps the child talking. Gifts plus a move to private chat is a pattern worth noting and sharing with your counselor. If the child mentions secrecy, pictures or threats, treat it as a possible disclosure (Module 6).
8	d	You do not investigate or confront.
9	c	Shame and fear of blame or punishment.
10	a	It names a signal, an action and a person to tell.

Take Action this week

- ☐ Find the name and number of your school counselor and write it on your Contact Card (Module 6 has a template).
- ☐ Find your school's mandated-reporter policy and read the first page.
- ☐ Ask one student, "What is a game or app you like right now?" Listen without correcting. (This is practice for Module 3.)
- ☐ Choose one statistic you have heard and trace it to its source.
- ☐ Tell one colleague about "Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell."
- ☐ Put your Honesty Map (Activity 1.1) somewhere safe for Module 8.

Further reading [VERIFY all links before sharing]

- Finkelhor, D., Walsh, K., Jones, L., Mitchell, K., and Collier, A. (2021). "Youth Internet Safety Education: Aligning Programs With the Evidence Base." *Trauma, Violence, & Abuse*. [VERIFY]
- UNICEF Office of Research, Disrupting Harm project: unicef.org/innocenti/projects/disrupting-harm [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]
- NCMEC sextortion data and CyberTipline data: ncmec.org and missingkids.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]
- FBI IC3 Annual Report and FBI explainer on financially motivated sextortion: ic3.gov and fbi.gov [VERIFY]
- Thorn research library: thorn.org/research [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]

- Pew Research Center, Teens, Social Media and AI Chatbots (December 2025): pewresearch.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]
- Common Sense Media, Talk, Trust, and Trade-Offs: How and Why Teens Use AI Companions (2025): commonsensemedia.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]
- eSafety Commissioner (Australia), on targeting behaviors rather than technologies: esafety.gov.au [site not reachable by the checker in Round 3B: VERIFY the page before linking]
- Hackles Teacher Primer (Teacher Support Pack, Document 1).

Specialist Corner

IF YOU TEACH COMPUTING, know that students trust the statistics a computing teacher cites, so the burden of accuracy is higher for you. Have students run their own "Number Detective" on a cybercrime headline and present how the original source differs. Show defenses, keep exploits at the conceptual level, and don't demo scary attacks live.

Where we go next

MODULE 2 IS WHERE you roll up your sleeves. You'll make a password, spot a phish and check your own privacy settings, all with fake data.

This module is educational guidance, not legal advice. Consult your district policy and counsel on reporting duties in your state.

QUICK CARD

Quick Card: Module 1, Why This Matters

The routine: Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.

The three promises: A false alarm is fine. It is never your fault. You will not be in trouble for telling.

Seven risk families (the shape, not the app): scams and tricks; taken-over accounts; unkind behavior; pressure from someone met online; sextortion; fake pictures, videos and voices; AI companions.

The pattern under all of them: pressure, secrecy, a request, and a move somewhere more private.

Handling numbers

- Quote the original source, not the headline. Say whether it counts reports or surveys a sample.
- Anything marked [VERIFY] gets checked before you repeat or print it.
- Share the shape ("real and rising; telling early gives more options"), not a scary number.

What the evidence favors

BETTER SUPPORTED	WEAK
Active, skill-based lessons (role-play, rehearsal)	One-off assemblies and single videos
Repeated, well-delivered programs	Information-only rules ("don't share personal information")
Teaching behaviors, not apps	Fear appeals with no action to take

Your role: Recognize, Teach, Listen, Report and hand off, Include. **Not your job:** investigating, confronting a suspect, viewing images, searching phones, counseling, fixing every device.

Say this

- To a child who tells you anything: "Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault. You are not in trouble."
- A good skill message names a signal to notice, one action, and a hopeful tone. Example: "If an account asks for your password or code, hackles up: pause and check with a trusted adult."
- If a child mentions a game "friend" with gifts: "Tell me more about it. What do you like about it?" Do not interrogate. Make a quiet note and tell your counselor per school process. If secrecy, pictures, threats or a move to a private app come up, treat it as a possible disclosure (Module 6).

Do this week

- ☐ Write your counselor's name and number on your Contact Card.
- ☐ Read the first page of your mandated-reporter policy.
- ☐ Trace one statistic to its original source.

